

Ἑκαταῖος ὁ Ἀβδηρίτης

Hecataeus of Abdera on Egypt and the Hyperboreans

eul_aid: hoe

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)

Dialect: Κοινή [Koine](#)

Domain: Ἱστορία [History](#)

Format: Συναγωγή [Collection](#)

Hecataeus of Abdera was a Greek historian and ethnographer of the early Hellenistic period, flourishing circa 320–300 BCE. A native of Abdera in Thrace, he served under Ptolemy I Soter and traveled to Thebes in Egypt to gather material for his writings. His career reflects the increased Greek intellectual engagement with foreign cultures following Alexander the Great's conquests.

His primary work was *On the Egyptians*, an ethnography of Egypt. He is also credited with a treatise *On the Hyperboreans*, concerning a mythical northern people, and possibly a work *On the Poetry of Homer and Hesiod*. All his writings are lost, surviving only as fragments and references in later authors, particularly Diodorus Siculus, who likely used Hecataeus's Egyptian ethnography as a major source.

Hecataeus is a significant early Hellenistic ethnographer. His *On the Egyptians* was an important source for later historians and shaped the Greek understanding of Egyptian culture. His work represents the genre of “barbarian history” and influenced later Jewish apologetic literature; his account of Jewish customs was used by Josephus. His reliability is debated, as his accounts blend observation with myth.

Works (4)

- Ἀποσπάσματα · [On Egyptian Philosophy and Religion](#) · 61 passages
- Ἀποσπάσματα · [On the Hyperboreans](#) · 20 passages
- Μαρτυρίαι Α' · [Testimonies 1](#) · 14 passages
- Μαρτυρίαι Β' · [Testimonies 2](#) · 6 passages